

young MP from Dausa, "As general secretary, he knows he is responsible for the youth wings and has brought in a paradigm shift in their functioning."

At the AICC session at Delhi's Talkatora Stadium last year, Rahul's speech on 'meritocracy' and eradication of poverty was not understood by many of his party workers. He was not surprised. He whispered to a colleague on the dais, "There don't seem to be that many poor people in this stadium." What has not gone down well with the rest of the Congress is that he seems to be running a parallel party organisation that bypasses the headquarters at 24, Akbar Road. As general secretary, his father had functioned out of his Safdarjung Road home assisted by Arun Nehru, Arun Singh, Vijay Dhar and Vishwajit Prithivijit Singh. Rahul, too, prefers to work from his Tughlaq Lane residence, dropping in at the party headquarters only for committee meetings. Bespectacled and laptop-lugging, Rahul's aides seem to have a printout for every solution. But as Rahul is slowly learning, parroting data is no substitute for a warm handshake. He has to put himself out there, among the people whose problems he wants to understand. "When I meet someone, I listen very carefully. You can learn a lot just by listening to someone. That is my job, to learn from them," he said at one of his press conferences.

Party leaders are not encouraged to accompany Rahul on his well-choreographed 'impromptu' visits to the states. Most don't even know his plans. Rahul's two-day visit to Bundelkhand in Madhya Pradesh last month left the state unit red-faced. Tikamgarh district chief Ravindra Adharvyuv told the media that while he was glad that Rahul had spent time among tribals, the party did not gain politically as it were not told about his visit. Rahul's aides point out that a Congress-style interaction with garlands and slogans is precisely what Rahul wants to avoid. Explains Congress leader Ajit Jogi, "He wants a direct interaction with the people without any intermediaries. This is what he enjoys." But most of his meetings still take place in a controlled atmosphere, the difference being that they are organised by NGOs instead

of party workers.

During one such organised interaction with artisans in Chhattisgarh's Kumhaarpara village, Rahul discussed their wages and the price of their products and promised them help with the marketing. But even here, because of his Special Protection Group, only a few got to meet him. He left without having put his finger on the pulse of the real problems. "If I had met Rahul, I would have said just three words: boring, boring, boring," said octogenarian Somini Baghel. Not that she found the khadi-and-sneakers-clad young man boring. In fact, she knew him only as 'Indira-Ma's grandson'. What she wanted to

Snapshots

"There is something wrong with a system that promotes hero worship."



SMALL TALK: A lover of fast cars, Rahul won't mind driving a Nano

3 Times he has spoken in Parliament. This includes two budget speeches and one special mention on the plight of sugarcane farmers in Uttar Pradesh.



The Chosen Way

■ He has made NREG his pet project. Rahul called on the prime minister on the eve of the Budget to ask for an extension, which was granted.

■ With a support system of young MPs who dress just like him, he prefers to work from his Tughlaq Lane residence.

■ His think-tank has submitted a report asking for elections to party posts at the district level to promote democracy.

tell him was that the village needed boring machines to draw more water. It is these day-to-day issues and not cricket matches that win the votes.

Instead of veteran party leaders, Rahul turns to his support group of young MPs such as Deora, Pilot, Jiten Prasad and Madhu Yaskhi. In Parliament he is often seen exchanging slips with fellow backbenchers, even prompting them to intervene. It was Rahul who told Prasad to speak during a discussion on the Uttar Pradesh bomb blasts last year and to bring up the Kandahar trade-off to stump BJP.

As part of his grooming, Rahul has been put on board two committees.